

A Brief Chronology of French Canada, 1534-1982

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As in any list, the choice of items retained is to a large extent arbitrary. I have included some events and dates that have affected French Canadians outside of Québec. I have also included items of a general nature since readers of *Yale French Studies* may not be familiar with the history of Canada. However, the story of French Canada always comes back to where it was (is) made and told: Québec, the Québécois, and Québécois texts. As for the latter, the choice was even more difficult to make. I have included important firsts. But the real problem is posed by the very *raison d'être* of this issue: the blossoming of Québécois literature in the sixties. Obviously, one can do no more than give a brief glimpse of the myriad of texts produced during that vibrant period of social, cultural, and political upheaval. In most cases, the titles retained received literary prizes whether it be the Governor General's Prize (*L'Incubation*), the Prix Fémina (*Bonheur d'occasion*, *Les Fous de Bassan*), or the Prix Goncourt (*Pélagie-la-Charette*). Not wanting to clutter the list needlessly, I have not included this information. It is, however, readily available in John Hare's excellent *Dictionnaire pratique des auteurs québécois*. I should like to thank Stuart Hughes of the Canadian Consulate in New York, Joseph Melançon of the Université Laval, Ben Shek of the University of Toronto, and Robin Winks of Yale University, for their invaluable help and suggestions. Any errors are, of course, my own. One final word. The capital cities in parentheses refer to the political jurisdiction responsible for the legislation in question whether it be imperial (London), federal (Ottawa), or provincial (Québec). Otherwise, the name *Québec* may be taken to mean the territory, the state, la Province de Québec.

- 1534 Jacques Cartier explores the Gulf of St. Lawrence and the St. Lawrence River and takes possession of the territory in the name of the King of France, Francis I
- 1545 *Bref Récit* by Jacques Cartier
- 1608 Québec (City) founded by Samuel de Champlain
- 1608–1700 10,000 original *colons* arrive in New France; approximately 20 percent are from Normandy
- 1609 First literary text of New France: *Les Muses de la Nouvelle France* by Marc Lescarbot
- 1613 *Les Voyages* by Samuel de Champlain
- 1632–73 Jesuit *Relations*
- 1642 Ville-Marie (i.e. Montréal) founded by Maisonneuve
- 1663 Royal government established in New France
Séminaire de Québec founded by Monsignor de Laval
- 1664 First history: *Histoire véritable et naturelle des moeurs et productions du pays de la Nouvelle France* by Pierre Boucher
- 1673 Fort Frontenac built (Kingston, Ontario)
- c.1680 Inhabitants of New France born in the colony begin to outnumber those born in France
- 1755 British expel 10,000 Acadians from Nova Scotia
- 1759 Battle of the Plains of Abraham; the British take Québec City; Generals Wolfe and Montcalm are killed; decisive defeat of French forces in North America
- 1760 British take Montréal
- 1760–1850 Population of the colony doubles every twenty-five years
- 1763 Treaty of Paris ends the Seven Years War; Britain opts for New France over Guadeloupe; 65,000 Canadiens become subjects of King George III; *la Cession*
Royal Proclamation gives colony new name: “Province of Quebec”; Catholics barred from holding public office
- 1764 *La Gazette de Québec*—colony’s first (bilingual) newspaper
- 1774 Quebec Act (London): borders of colony expanded; Canadiens exempted from Test Act and thus eligible to sit on Legislative Council; old French civil law recognized
“Address to the Inhabitants of the Province of Quebec” by the first Congress of the American colonies
- 1776 Benjamin Franklin’s mission to Montréal fails

- 1776–89 Movement of British Loyalists to present-day Canada
- 1783 Treaty of Paris: Ohio Valley portion of former New France ceded to the United States
- 1791 Constitutional Act (London); creation of Upper Canada (Ontario) and Lower Canada (Québec)
- 1799 Assembly of Lower Canada votes to give 20,000 pounds sterling to Britain to help her fight France
- 1806 *Le Canadien* founded
- 1812 United States declares war on Great Britain
- 1813 American soldiers repulsed at Châteauguay by French-Canadian Voltigeurs
- Mc Gill College founded
- 1830 First literary text published in book form in French Canada: *Epître, satires, chansons, épigrammes et autres pièces de vers* by Michel Bibaud
- 1831 Alexis de Tocqueville visits Lower Canada
- 1837 First novel published in French Canada: *L'Influence d'un livre* by Philippe Aubert de Gaspé, fils
- Insurrection in Lower (and Upper) Canada
- 1838 Robert Nelson proclaims "La République du Bas Canada"
- Twelve *Patriotes* hanged in Montréal
- 1839 Lord Durham's *Report on the Affairs of British North America*
- 1840 Act of Union (London): Lower Canada ceases to exist as a separate political entity; English sole official language
- 1844 Institut Canadien de Montréal founded to provide intellectual forum for graduates of *collèges classiques* in the absence of a French-speaking university
- 1845–48 *Histoire du Canada depuis sa découverte jusqu'à nos jours* by François-Xavier Garneau
- 1849 First official recognition of French language since Act of Union
- 1851–1900 500,000 French Canadians emigrate to the United States
- 1852 Université Laval founded
- 1855 Visit of *La Capricieuse*, the first French ship to arrive in Québec since the Conquest
- 1862 "Promenade des trois morts" by Octave Crémazie
- Jean Rivard, le défricheur* by Antoine Gérin-Lajoie
- 1863 *Les Anciens Canadiens* by Philippe Aubert de Gaspé, père

- 1866 Fenians attack Canada from the United States
- 1867 British North America Act (London), Canada's constitutional document for 115 years: "Confederation"—three British colonies form a new country called the Dominion of Canada; Québec becomes one of the four new provinces; French is recognized in the national Parliament and the provincial Parliament of Québec
32% of Canada is French-speaking; 85% of the province of Québec is Francophone
- 1868 First contingent of Zouaves leaves for Italy to defend the Pope's temporal authority
- 1871 80% of the population of Québec is rural
- 1875 Body of Joseph Guibord (d. 1869), printer, member, and sometime president of the liberal Institut Canadien de Montréal, is finally buried in a Catholic cemetery under order from the Privy Council in London
- 1876 Branch campus of Laval established in Montréal
- 1880 Louis Fréchette receives a prize from the Académie française for his poetry
- 1882 First novel written by a woman: *Angéline de Montbrun* by Laure Conan
- 1885 Execution of messianic Métis leader Louis Riel in Regina, Saskatchewan
First visit of Sarah Bernhardt to Montréal provokes condemnation by Church
- 1890s Large numbers of immigrants arrive in English-speaking Canada
- 1890 Legal status of French language in Manitoba all but abolished
- 1895 "Ecole littéraire de Montréal" founded
Pour la patrie by Jules-Paul Tardivel: "A religious and separatist vision of Québec in the mid-twentieth century"
- 1896 First French-Canadian Prime Minister of Canada, Wilfrid Laurier
- 1900 60% of the population of Québec is rural
- 1902 Société du parler français au Canada founded
"La vocation de la race française en Amérique" by Monsignor L.-A. Paquet

- 1907 La Fédération Nationale Saint-Jean-Baptiste founded
Ecole des Hautes Etudes Commerciales opened in
Montréal
Essais sur la littérature canadienne by Camille Roy
- 1910 *Le Devoir* founded by Henri Bourassa
- 1911 52% of the population of Québec is rural
- 1912–27 Regulation 17 in force in Ontario: teaching of French in so-called “bilingual” schools limited to one hour per day
- 1914 *Maria Chapdelaine* by the French writer Louis Hémon first published in serial form in *Le Temps*, Paris
Parliament at Westminster declares war on the German and Austro-Hungarian Empires in the name of the British Empire, including Canada and the other Dominions
- 1917–18 Conscription crisis
- 1918 *La Scouine* by Albert Laberge
- 1920 Université de Montréal established as an autonomous institution
- 1927 Bilingual postage stamps (Ottawa)
- 1929 63% of the population of Québec is urban
- 1931 Statute of Westminster (London): Canada acquires full autonomy in foreign affairs; the British monarch becomes the personal sovereign of Canada
Unemployment affects 26% of the unionized labor force in the province; 100,000 people in Montréal receive financial assistance
- 1936 Bilingual paper money (Ottawa)
- 1936–39 Maurice Duplessis, Prime Minister of Québec
- 1936–44 *Notre maître, le passé* by Canon Lionel Groulx
- 1937 *Menaud, maître-draveur* by Félix-Antoine Savard
- 1938 *Trente arpents* by Philippe Panneton (pseud. Ringuet)
- 1939 Canada declares war on Germany and Italy
- 1940 Women obtain the right to vote in Québec
- 1941 Death of Emile Nelligan after forty-two years of internment in various hospitals; the critical edition of his *Poésies complètes 1896–1899* will be published in 1952
- 1942 Law on compulsory school attendance (Québec)
In a national plebiscite, Québec votes against conscription

- for overseas service by 72%; other provinces vote 80% in favor
- Law on conscription for overseas service (Ottawa)
- 1944 *Au pied de la pente douce* by Roger Lemelin
- 1944–59 Maurice Duplessis, Prime Minister of Québec
- 1945 *Le Survenant* by Germaine Guèvremont
- Bonheur d'occasion* by Gabrielle Roy
- 1948 Fleur de lys emblem designated as official flag of Québec
- Refus global* by Paul-Emile Borduas; as a result of publication of the Automatist manifesto, Borduas loses his position at the Ecole du meuble in Montréal
- Tit-coq* by Gatien Gélinas
- 1949 *Poésies complètes* by Saint-Denys Garneau (d. 1943)
- 1949–50 Asbestos strike
- 1950 Forced retirement of Monsignor Joseph Charbonneau (d. 1959) to Victoria, British Columbia after he takes position in favor of Asbestos strikers
- End of judicial appeals to the Privy Council (London)
- Cité libre* founded by Gérard Pelletier and Pierre Elliott Trudeau
- 1951 70% of the population of Québec is urban
- 1953 *Poussière sur la ville* by André Langevin
- 1958 Creation of Ministère du Bien-être social et de la jeunesse (Québec)
- Agaguk* by Yves Thériault
- 1959 Death of Maurice Duplessis
- Appointment of first French Canadian as Governor General of Canada, General Georges Vanier
- Liberté* founded
- 1960–c.1966 The Quiet Revolution
- 1960 Defeat of Union Nationale Party
- Creation of the Office de la langue française (Québec)
- Le Libraire* by Gérard Bessette
- Les Insolences du Frère Untel* by Jean-Paul Desbiens
- 1961 Mouvement laïc de langue française founded
- Hospital insurance instituted (Québec)
- Francophones represent about 30% of the population of Canada; on average French-speaking workers in the

- province of Québec earn 35% less than their English-speaking counterparts
- 1962 "Réseau de résistance" formed
Contes du pays incertain by Jacques Ferron
- 1963 Bombs are placed at the Wolfe-Montcalm monument in Québec City
First death as a result of bombs planted by the FLQ (Front de Libération du Québec)
Establishment of Royal Commission on Bilingualism and Biculturalism (Ottawa)
Parti pris founded
Ode au Saint-Laurent by Gatién Lapointe
- 1964 Creation of Ministère de l'éducation (Québec)
Terre Québec by Paul Chamberland
Le Cassé by Jacques Renaud
- 1965 Maple leaf flag replaces Red Ensign as flag of Canada
Birthrate in Québec is 5% lower than in the rest of Canada
Prochain épisode by Hubert Aquin
L'Incubation by Gérard Bessette
Une saison dans la vie d'Emmanuel by Marie-Claire Blais
Dans un gant de fer by Claire Martin
- 1966 *L'Avalée des avalés* by Réjean Ducharme
- 1967 Creation of secular junior college system
Expo 67
Visit of Charles de Gaulle: "Vive le Québec libre!"
Salut Galarneau! by Jacques Godbout
- 1968 Riot in Montréal on occasion of Saint-Jean-Baptiste parade
Pierre Elliott Trudeau, Prime Minister of Canada
Independentist Parti Québécois formed
Divorce Act (Ottawa): divorce legalized in Québec
La guerre, yes sir! by Roch Carrier
Les Belles-soeurs by Michel Tremblay
Nègres blancs d'Amérique by Pierre Vallières
- 1969 Canadian army intervenes in Montréal during strikes
Official Languages Act (Ottawa)
"Speak White" by Michèle Lalonde
- 1970 Kidnapping of British Trade Representative, James Cross, and Pierre Laporte, Ministre du Travail et de l'Immi-

gration, by FLQ cells; death in captivity of Laporte; occupation of Montréal by Canadian army and suspension of Habeas Corpus under the War Measures Act (Ottawa); some 500 trade unionists, political activists, and writers are arrested and detained.

Kamouraska by Anne Hébert

L'Homme rapaillé by Gaston Miron

1972 *Un Rêve québécois* by Victor-Lévy Beaulieu

1973 "La Deffence & Illustration de la langue quebecquoyse" by Michèle Lalonde

1974 *Mécanique jongleuse* and *Masculin grammaticale* by Nicole Brossard

1976 Parti Québécois forms government of the province, headed by René Lévesque

1977 Charte de la langue française (Québec): French is sole official language

1978 *Les Fées ont soif* by Denise Boucher

La Grosse femme d'à côté est enceinte by Michel Tremblay

1979 *Le Semestre* by Gérard Bessette

Pélagie-la-Charrette by Antonine Maillet

1980 Provincial referendum on *souveraineté-association*: 59.5% vote "Non"

1981 Francophones represent 26% of the population of Canada and 82% of the population of Québec; 80% of the population of the province is urban

1982 The Constitutional Act (Ottawa) replaces the BNA Act (London): Canada remains a constitutional monarchy and member of the Commonwealth

The Supreme Court of Canada rejects Québec's right to a veto over changes to the constitution

Les Fous de Bassan by Anne Hébert